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Sorting the confusion about the numerous versions of the Barratt Impulsiveness Scale

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The Barratt Impulsiveness Scale (BIS) is one of the most widely used self-report questionnaires for the assessment of impulsivity as a trait. The original BIS was developed by Ernest S. Barratt in 1959 [1]. Since then, the scale has been revised several times and the current version is the BIS-11 [1]. Note that the number 11 does not refer to the number of items included in the questionnaire but to the number of revisions, that is, the BIS-11 is the 11th version of the BIS, which has 30 items. There is also a provisional version of the BIS-11—the BIS-11A—that was distributed during development of the BIS-11 and that has been more widely disseminated and used than was intended. As the BIS-11 and BIS-11A only share 24 items in common, it has been recommended that the BIS-11A should not be used [1].

Complicating matters, abbreviated versions of the BIS-11 have been developed in the past decades. These include, for example, the BIS-Brief, which includes 8 of the BIS-11's 30 items [2]. Another popular short form of the BIS-11 is the BIS-15 developed by Spinella [3]. In contrast to the BIS-11, the number 15 refers to the number of items included in the questionnaire, that is, the BIS-15 contains 15 items of the 30-item BIS-11. As of this writing (June 2023), the article by Spinella [3] has been cited more than 600 times according to Google Scholar and translated versions of the BIS-15 have been used in several other languages such as German, French, Spanish, Thai, and Kannada (see [4] for an overview).

Recently, Maggi and colleagues [5] reported on the development of a short version of the Italian BIS-11 in this journal. Unfortunately, they named this short form of the BIS-11 the BIS-15, obviously being unaware that a version with such a name already exists (i.e., the article

by Spinella [3] or any other article about the BIS-15 is not cited in that article). This is particularly unfortunate as the items of Spinella's BIS-15 and Maggi et al.'s BIS-15 are not identical. While 12 items of the two versions overlap, Spinella's BIS-15 include the items "I plan for the future.", "I am restless at lectures or talks.", and "I squirm at plays or lectures." while Maggi et al.'s BIS-15 include the items "I am happy-go-lucky.", "I am self-controlled.", and "I spend or charge more than I earn."

While I appreciate the effort of Maggi and colleagues [5] to develop a short form that is more psychometrically sound than the Italian BIS-11 (and it is quite remarkable that this lead to a selection of items closely similar to the English items selected by Spinella [3]), it further adds to the confusion that there are several versions of the BIS in general and several short versions of the BIS-11 in particular. Thus, Maggi and colleagues or other researchers who use the Italian BIS-15 may consider referring to it with a different name to avoid confusing this scale with Spinella's BIS-15. I further suggest that Maggi and colleagues may reanalyze their data and examine if using the BIS-Brief's 8 items or the original BIS-15's 15 items may also represent psychometrically sound short versions of the Italian BIS-11. If so, using these versions will facilitate comparability across studies and reduce confusion about the different versions of the BIS.

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